



\$1.8 million

A representative of Vijay Mallya makes the winning bid (left) at a New York auction house for a collection of Mahatma Gandhi's personal items (above).

take to Gandhian ways. That he has, but with some doubt as to his motives. In fact, Ruhe himself admits that he has been selling Gandhian items from 1998 onwards. His website, called Gandhiserve, lists prices of documents and photographs relating to the Mahatma. Ruhe first came to India in the early 80s as a Gandhi admirer and soon won the confidence of Purshottam and Kanu, who lived in Rajkot with his wife Abha. Both had a good collection of Gandhi's photographs and articles. Purshottam is famous as one who was part of Gandhi's Tolstoy and Phoenix experiments as a small child in South Africa. Purshottam passed away in the 1990s and Abha in 1995.

What seems to have kept Ruhe's name away from the spotlight is that many of the sellers were unwilling to admit that they had sold items in their possession for fear of ridicule and being accused of lack of patriotism. One

of them is Upen Mehta, son of late photographer Jagan Mehta, who took pictures of Gandhi's historical peace march in Bihar following communal riots in 1947. Upen revealed recently that Ruhe had paid money to his father for the photographs. In the past few months, Ruhe has been writing letters to such eminent persons as Gandhi's grandson Rajmohan Gandhi and Gandhian Narayan Desai, son of the Mahatma's secretary Mahadev Desai, seeking royalty under the Berne Convention for pictures they have used from "his collection" in their books sold outside India. He claims that he holds the copyright outside India of Gandhi's pictures and belongings in his possession. He also claims that the proceeds from the sale or royalty of the Gandhian items he possesses are used by his foundation, Gandhiserve, "for Gandhian purposes". The Gandhiserve website says that the foundation as part of the

SHAILESH RAVAL/www.indiatodayimages.com



Fifty per cent of the money that comes from the sale of these images and articles goes to their owners and remaining 50 per cent to the foundation.

PETER RUHE, German collector

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Photographs 020512 D
Personalities Mahatma Gandhi - 1935-1937 (Duotone)

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5x7	\$1.99
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Gandhi's Memorabilia

248 art items

2,947 letters

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31 cartoons

407 documents

513 publications

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